

Blood Brother

By M. V. Baldur

It was the only noise that spread through the air: the sound of a sharpening knife. With every scrape of the stone against the blade, sparks flew around the campers. It was the third source of light—joining the moon and the campfire.

Two men were sitting nearby the fire; it was their time to watch. While one sharpened his knife, the other simply looked around. That was the moment he noticed a rustling in the bushes. A first thought always accuses the wind of making such noises, but he stood up anyway to be sure.

With a long, quiet whistle, he drew his sword from its scabbard and walked toward the dancing bushes. It happened suddenly—quicker than the man could even realize that the blade was slicing his head into two unequal parts.

The knife sharpener was quicker to react to the sight of his friend's halved head than his dead companion had been. Throwing his sharpening stone to one side, he scrambled to his feet. As he rose, he opened his mouth wide to shout and wake his sleeping companions, but before a sound could escape, a massive hand clamped over his face. Before he could swing his own weapon, a sharper blade passed clean through his chest.

There were two attackers, and they continued the slaughter in absolute silence. Slowly, one by one, they cut the throats of the rogues—"Jönir's Sons," as they called themselves—dropping them like broken hoops under the dark sky.

One of the men sat down next to the fire. He was the larger of the two, possessing striking blue eyes. Even in the deep darkness, those piercing eyes were enough to strike fear into any rogue—if only they had known who Arirthel was.

The other attacker joined Arirthel after retrieving a small firkin of beer. He was skinnier, with long, loose hair as he sat down beside him. He carried many nicknames, but the most infamous was Crawfolk the Dangler. He had a reputation that rivaled the most well-known bards, though his fame did not come from music.

"Maybe, just maybe, we could take a piece of the jewelry," Crawfolk muttered. "Maybe a ring, or... or a necklace. Even one diamond off the necklace would work. It would be enough money for us to live out the rest of our lives, and..."

"So, you are suggesting that we steal jewelry that is already stolen, which we were specifically requested to return to its rightful owner?"

"Both of us know the Queen probably won't even recognize it's missing. But yeah, yeah... you and your loyal heart would never let us do those kinds of things. I just wanted to try my luck."

He threw the heavy sack down in front of Arirthel, and the stolen royal treasures spilled out. The crackling firelight danced across the gems. Arirthel sat motionless, staring at the shifting shadows as if frozen.

"Arirthy," Crawfolk said after a long silence. "If staring at the jewelry isn't going to change your mind, maybe we should move out. You know, we both smell like a bunch of... well, shit and blood. And brother, what's worse..." He leaned closer to his companion. "...is that Arirthel hasn't bathed since the day he was born. Wait, did they even wash you when you were born?"

"Crowley, you will just have to get along with the bath we just took in blood. Gather the jewelry and keep an eye out for a river or a lake. As you said, we need to wash our armor."

"Will it be the first time you've ever washed, Sir Arirthel?" Crawford asked with a bastard smile, taking a heavy swig of his beer.

"Unlike you, my armor usually gets painted with blood. Yours..." Arirthel moved like lightning, striking the bottom of the vessel and splashing the alcohol right back into Crawford's face, "...is usually painted with wine, bought with the gold I earn."

Crawford couldn't hold it in; the beer sprayed from his mouth as he burst out laughing. "All right, all right, you won this round."

"Indeed. Take the jewelry with you. Try not to drop it in whatever water you find. If you can't find any, well... we ride caked in blood," Arirthel said, pulling himself up. "Be careful, Folk."

"You too, Arirthy, you too," Crawford said, extending his forearm. Arirthel caught his arm and nodded. Breaking their hold, they separated into the dark woods in opposite directions.

Arirthel closed his eyes once he was deep within the forest, ensuring there was no light except for the weak glow of the moon and stars breaking through the canopy. The thick leaves and heavy branches blocked out most of the sky. The dark, windy forests of the West were not strange to Arirthel; he had marched through them a few times before.

Taking a deep breath, he slowly reached for his weapon. Without opening his eyes, his sword left its scabbard with a long, cold whistle. He began to swing the blade in a measured rhythm. It brought him a strange peace—dancing with shadows under a midnight sky. Breathing evenly, he moved forward. One step ahead. Stop. Swing the sword above his head. Another step. Trace an imaginary circle with the tip of the blade. Stop again. He raised the sword high and suddenly drove it into the dirt.

Without opening his eyes, he unclasped his arm-rings and hung them from his belt. Retaking his sword, he resumed his dance of death, moving faster and with heavier, more aggressive strokes. With every swing, he felt the night wind rushing past his bare hands, arms, and face. The only sound in the air was the whistling of his blade. He was entirely alone—which was exactly why he loved the dark forest. Usually, nobody bothers you here.

Not tonight, however.

Arirthel caught the distinct crunch of grass and the sudden rustle of bushes. Without hesitation, he lunged forward, his heart rate spiking. It wasn't fear; it was his body preparing itself for the slaughter, the combat, and the blood.

Spinning around, he brought his sword down in the same fluid motion, opening his eyes just in time to halt the blade mid-swing. The distance between life and death was shorter than the split second it took for his weapon to whistle through the air.

Arirthel exhaled slowly, filling his chest with an uneasy calm. His sword was pointed directly at an old, stocky man who stood staring at him like a corpse. He was nearly half

Arirthel's height, but he was no dwarf—just a chunky, eccentric man whom Arirthel had met a long time ago.

"Mr. Willock, you are one of the bravest men I know. No one else dares to sneak up on me," Arirthel said, sliding his sword back into its scabbard.

"Well, I am not afraid of you, Arirthel. I know you are an honorable Knight working for the Queen, which means you work for me too. No need for true bravery to approach an old friend. Am I wrong?"

"No, Mr. Willock. You are entirely right."

"Aye. Then tell me, what brings you back to my lands? Is it about..."

"Rogues," Arirthel answered flatly. "Crawfolk and I are hunting Jönir's sons. They..."

"Stole from the Queen's treasury," Willock interrupted, finishing his sentence.

"Yes. Regardless, we handled it, so we are on our way," Arirthel said. Without looking at Willock's face again, he turned and began walking back through the trees.

"At night? Are you certain? You need rest... and a proper bath to wash away all that blood covering you."

"We are not butchers, Mr. Willock. I am a Knight of the Queen; I am accustomed to walking in blood."

"Perhaps you are, but not Crawfolk."

"I am sure I can find a lake or a river to drown him in. For cleaning purposes, of course."

"My apologies, but there are no water sources nearby. Besides, you look like you've cut more than ten men's throats tonight. You both need rest."

"Thank you, Mr. Willock, but we must press on."

"But you look exhausted! Just let me help you. Let me host you for the night."

Arirthel stopped, and Mr. Willock paused behind him. Arirthel drew a long, heavy breath. "Mr. Willock, you are far too stubborn to argue with. Just like a long-bearded goat. I will extend your offer to my friend first. If he accepts, we will stay the night. By tomorrow morning, we ride for the kingdom."

"Are you sure you don't wish to stay longer? You know..."

"She is history now, Mr. Willock. I ruined it. Respectfully." Arirthel stood in silence for a brief moment. "Crawfolk's horse is just over there." He pointed toward a brown mare with a distinct white mark. "Go on ahead. I want to run with Arth; I'll catch up to you."

"As you wish, Arirthel. Though I want to thank you for accepting my invitation. I don't know what else I can do to repay you. I am in your debt for the rest of my days because you saved my life. Do you remember?"

"It was years ago. I can scarcely remember it," Arirthel lied, though he remembered the exact date and hour perfectly.

"Don't worry, I can recount your great tale to Crawfolk while you try to remember it," Willock said, untying the bridle of the brown horse before mounting it. Arirthel stepped to the animal's left side, grabbing the bridle briefly to guide its direction.

"Ride that way. Do not turn left or right. Keep her straight, and you will find our camp."

Mr. Willock nodded and rode off into the dark.

Once Willock disappeared from sight, Arirthel shook the reins of his stallion, steering him deeper into the dark forest, urging him to a brisk pace around the thick trees.

"Arth, my friend, let's ride like a stormy wind! Let's race the gale itself! Gee ho!" Arirthel yelled, spurring his mount.

Arth quickened his pace, neighing loudly as he broke into a full gallop. Arirthel felt the cold night air whipping hard against his face. It brought him the exact peace he sought—a fleeting escape to clear his chaotic thoughts, trying desperately to forget her and the disappointment he had left behind.

After a while, as he neared the campsite, Arirthel could hear boisterous laughter echoing through the trees. It was no surprise to see Crawfolk and Mr. Willock getting along so famously. They were basic men at heart: driven by wine, women, and coin—undoubtedly the three topics they were currently discussing alongside their various exploits. Arirthel knew most of Willock's stories were total fabrications, but Crawfolk had plenty of real ones from his travels with Arirthel.

"Finally, my honorable brother returns!" Crawfolk bellowed as Arirthel approached. "Your wealthy friend here says we are invited to be his guests for a few nights."

"Just one night, Crowley," Arirthel corrected immediately.

"You are welcome to stay longer if you like," Willock added.

"No, thank you for your hospitality, but we depart at dawn. Let's move," Arirthel said, turning his stallion back toward the road. "Gee ha!"

"He does that sometimes," Crawfolk told Willock with a shrug. "He's more of a duty-first kind of guy."

"You two are so completely different. Is there anything you actually have in common?" Willock asked, mounting his horse behind Crawfolk.

"Hmm," Crawfolk mused as Willock settled in behind him. "Well, we are both exceptional fighters, I suppose. We've fought shoulder-to-shoulder more times than I can count. That's what makes us brothers." With that, Crawfolk spurred his horse, following Arirthel's lead.

After a long trek through the dark woods, they finally hit an open path. Though still surrounded by trees, they no longer had to weave around jagged rocks and undergrowth. They just had to follow the trail.

The path was short, opening up to thick wooden palisades and a pair of sentries. At first, the guards couldn't identify the riders under the dark sky and raised their weapons, but as the horses drew close enough for the torchlight to illuminate their faces, the gates were thrown open.

The first building inside the city walls was an inn, featuring a large, weathered signboard depicting a gray pig. Beneath the painting, text was etched into the wood. As they rode past The Grey Pig Inn, Crawfolk asked, "Is it true that the best pork chops in the North are cooked right here?"

"Every word of it is true!" Willock answered proudly. "And you're in luck! We shall have some the moment we arrive at my estate!"

"I am incredibly glad to hear that. We haven't had a proper meal since we started tracking those rogues. I need that pork." Crawfolk glanced to his left with a massive grin. "And I certainly need those, too." He gestured toward an old, sprawling building decorated heavily in vibrant red and purple banners. Most of its lamps were lit, and the muffled sounds of music and laughter spilled out into the street. Three scantily clad women stood out front—a redhead, a blonde, and a brunette. They waved playfully at Crawfolk, who responded with a genuine smile.

Arirthel exhaled heavily, looking back over his shoulder at his companions. Once they cleared the brothel, Crawfolk caught his glare, his eyebrows shooting up at Arirthel's cold, serious expression.

"What?" Crawfolk asked defensively. "I might be an honorable Knight, but I am still a man. A single man has needs..."

"Perhaps you should keep those thoughts to yourself, brother. Truly, you should," Arirthel snapped, cutting him off short.

"All right, all right, you tough old Knight. As you wish."

For a brief period, they rode in an unbelievable silence. Crawfolk held his tongue for the remainder of the journey toward Mr. Willock's estate, while Arirthel kept his position in the vanguard, leading them home.

"You claim to have forgotten everything, yet you still remember the way to my house," Willock noted as they finally brought their horses to a halt.

"How could I ever forget this place," Arirthel murmured, his eyes locked onto the manor.

TO BE CONTINUED...